



**NATIONAL GOVTECH
POLICY ROUNDTABLE
2026**

Theme:

Digital First Governance:
Rethinking How Nigerian
Governments Serve, Engage
and Deliver.

**COMMUNIQUE
ISSUED AT THE END OF THE
NATIONAL GOVTECH POLICY
ROUNDTABLE 2026
HELD ON 30TH MARCH 2026 AT THE
NATIONAL ASSEMBLY LIBRARY AND
RESOURCE CENTRE, ABUJA**



1.0 PREAMBLE

The National GovTech Policy Roundtable 2026 was convened on Monday, 30th March 2026, at the National Assembly Library and Resource Centre, Abuja, under the theme “Digital First Governance: Rethinking How Nigerian Governments Serve, Engage and Deliver”. The Roundtable was co-convened by GovTech Africa Inc., the Office of the Deputy Speaker at the House of Representatives, and the National Assembly Library Trust Fund.

The event brought together a broad cross-section of stakeholders (from key government components across the federal executive, legislature, and judiciary, as well as sub-national governments) to the private sector and international development partners, reaffirming the Roundtable’s whole-of-government character.

The discussions were anchored on the recognition that Nigeria’s greatest digital governance challenge is no longer primarily technological, it is institutional and cultural. The persistent gap between policy intent and implementation, the duplication of siloed systems, limited interoperability across government institutions, and the absence of enforcement mechanisms that outlast individual administrations remain the primary barriers to transformation. The Roundtable was convened as a working platform to ask the right questions, challenge existing assumptions, and co-create practical and actionable steps toward a digital-first republic.

2.0 ATTENDANCE

The Roundtable was attended by the Speaker of the House of Representatives (represented by the Official Spokesperson of the House, Rep. Akin Rotimi Jnr.); the Deputy Speaker of the House of Representatives, (H.E. Rt. Hon. Benjamin Okezie Kalu, PhD, CFR); the Honourable Minister of Communications, Innovation and Digital Economy (represented by the MD/CEO of Galaxy Backbone Limited, Prof. Ibrahim Adepoju Adeyanju); the Regional Director for Africa at Govtech Africa Inc. (Mr. Fortune Toma); the Executive Secretary of the National Assembly Library Trust Fund (Hon. Henry Nwawuba); the Ambassador of Finland to Nigeria (H.E. Ms. Sanna Selin); the High Commissioner of Rwanda to Nigeria (H.E. Moses Rugema); the Head of the Civil Service of the Federation (represented by her Senior Technical Advisor, Dr. Gideon Adogbo); and the Chief Registrar of the Supreme Court of Nigeria (represented by the Deputy Chief Registrar).

Institutional representation further spanned the National Information Technology Development Agency (NITDA); the Nigeria Data Protection Commission (NDPC); the Presidential Enabling Business Environment Council (PEBEC); the Bureau of Public Service Reforms (BPSR); the Nigerian Governors

Forum (NGF); Open Government Partnership (OGP) Nigeria; the Nigeria Interbank Settlement System (NIBSS); Remita Payment Services Limited (RPSL); the Nigerian Immigration Service (NIS); the National Assembly Budget and Research Office (NABRO); the Nigerian Economic Summit Group (NESG); the Nigerian Midstream and Downstream Petroleum Regulatory Authority (NMDPRA); the National Institute for Legislative and Democratic Studies (NILDS); the Nigeria Export Processing Zones Authority; the Nigerian Upstream Petroleum Regulatory Commission (NUPRC); the National Space Research and Development Agency (NSRDA); the Nigerian Center for Disease Control (NCDC); Abuja Global Shapers Community; and the general public.

3.0 KEY OBSERVATIONS

The Roundtable was highly interactive and exhaustively deliberated upon. At the end of the proceedings, participants observed and noted the following:

1. Nigeria has made commendable progress in digital public infrastructure — including National Identity Number (NIN) enrolment reaching 126 million citizens, an expanded national database of 250 million records, operational interbank payment systems, and early steps toward whole-of-government digital coordination — yet progress remains uneven and significant challenges persist.
2. A 2025 sub-national digital maturity assessment of 34 states, conducted in partnership with the Nigerian Governors' Forum, found that only two states have achieved high digital maturity, while 12 states remain at low maturity. Unreliable electricity supply and unstable connectivity were identified as primary contributors to this disparity.
3. The imperative of a digital-first governance posture — one in which digital thinking is embedded in the architecture of how government is designed, not treated as an afterthought, a modernisation exercise, or a donor-funded pilot — was affirmed across all panels.
4. The National Digital Economy and e-Governance Bill, currently before the National Assembly, was recognised as the most consequential digital governance legislation of this era, providing the legal framework for interoperability, mandated digital compliance across all tiers, shared services delivery, and a national framework for eliminating duplication across Ministries, Departments and Agencies (MDAs).
5. Citizens today compare government services not with yesterday's bureaucracy but with today's digital experiences — fast, seamless, and responsive. The standard of citizen-centricity must

therefore be elevated: every digital service must be evaluated by whether it reduces the time, cost, and friction of engaging with government for the average Nigerian, including persons with disabilities, those with limited digital literacy, and those in low-connectivity environments.

6. Data protection and trust are preconditions for digital adoption. The Nigeria Data Protection Commission (NDPC) has made measurable progress in supporting MDA compliance, including through Data Privacy Impact Assessments, the designation of Data Protection Officers, and the signing of compliance frameworks with multiple states. However, the pace of compliance must accelerate across all 36 states.
7. The GovMail platform, developed by Galaxy Backbone Limited and currently being deployed with the support of the Office of the Head of the Civil Service of the Federation, is fully operational with over 100,000 civil servant accounts. Adoption remains incomplete, including within the National Assembly — a gap the Deputy Speaker publicly committed to closing from the floor of the Roundtable.
8. Nigeria possesses world-class homegrown government technology (such as Remita's payment solution, which powers all federal government financial transactions, and the NIBSS stack, which underpins the national payments system) yet these achievements are insufficiently celebrated, insufficiently replicated in public procurement decisions, and insufficiently positioned as proof of Nigeria's capacity for technology-enabled governance.
9. The persistent duplication of IT investments across MDAs, the absence of an ICT-specific procurement framework, and the lack of a trained IT procurement cadre within government were identified as structural weaknesses that undermine value for money, generate waste, and impede sustainability across administrations.
10. The judiciary has commenced a phased digitisation programme — including an electronic diary, the Nigeria Case Management System (piloted in five states), and preparation of practice directions for electronic filing — demonstrating that even traditionally paper-bound institutions can achieve meaningful transformation through structured, phased implementation.
11. Finland's commitment of a 23 million Euro EU-funded programme — implemented through a Team Finland initiative with the Estonian development cooperation — to strengthen Nigeria's digital public services and support talent development through the 3 Million Technical Talent programme was welcomed as a model of international partnership grounded in national ownership.
12. A whole-of-government approach to digital transformation is not optional — it is structurally required. Government cannot build a digital-first republic through isolated agency initiatives. The co-creation of shared platforms, interoperable systems, and a common national digital architecture must be the operating model.

4.0 RESOLUTIONS

After series of presentations, deliberations, and conversations on the subject matter of Digital First Governance, the Roundtable resolved as follows:

1. Every digital service deployed by government must be evaluated against one metric: does it reduce the time, cost, and friction of engaging with government for the average Nigerian? (Including those with disabilities, limited connectivity, and low digital literacy) Accessibility is not optional; it is the definition of success. Digital services must be designed to receive, process, and act on citizen feedback as a core function, not an afterthought.
2. The National Assembly shall prioritise the expeditious conclusion of the bill processes for the National Digital Economy and e-Governance Bill, with a call for the President of the Federal Republic of Nigeria to assent to it without delay. The Bill shall be treated as a national legislative emergency, not a procedural exercise.
3. Government institutions at all levels are enjoined to transition from building isolated digital projects to contributing to shared, reusable platforms. New administrations must build on existing digital infrastructure rather than discard it. The Office of the Head of the Civil Service shall develop a Digital Platform Continuity and Transition Framework as part of the Federal Civil Service Strategy and Implementation Plan 2026–2030.
4. A deliberate Nigeria-First technology principle shall govern all public digital investment decisions, giving deliberate preference to Nigerian-built solutions that meet defined security, interoperability, and quality standards. Celebrating and scaling Nigerian-built solutions is both a sovereignty and a competitiveness imperative.
5. All government officials at the federal and state levels are enjoined to transition immediately from commercial email services (such as those provided by google and microsoft) to Galaxy Backbone's GovMail platform. The National Assembly formally commits to this transition, beginning with the Office of the Deputy Speaker. This directive shall be enforced through a circular by the Office of the Head of the Civil Service of the Federation.
6. Each arm of government - the Executive, the Legislature, and the Judiciary shall develop and publish a Digital Transformation Plan, setting out a time-bound roadmap for modernising its operations, service delivery, and citizen engagement. No arm of government may credibly champion digital-first governance without first applying that standard to its own institution. All MDAs shall key into the Digital Transformation Plan relative to the arm of government under which it operates.
7. The Nigeria Data Exchange (NGDX) shall be activated with binding cross-MDA compliance

mandates, operationalising the principle that citizens and businesses provide data to government only once, with agencies retrieving it securely through the exchange. The absence of harmonisation after years of policy commitment is no longer acceptable.

8. The Nigeria Data Protection Commission shall complete its MDA compliance programme to include mandatory Data Privacy Impact Assessments, Data Protection Officer designations, and annual audit submissions within 12 months. State-level data protection compliance frameworks shall be extended to all 36 states and the FCT.
9. The Open Government Partnership (OGP) co-creative model (with 50/50 participation between government and civil society) shall inform the design of Nigeria's multi-stakeholder digital governance architecture. All institutions present commit to active participation in the implementation of Nigeria's Fourth OGP National Action Plan, treating it as a live instrument of accountability rather than a periodic filing requirement.
10. A NASS Eye digital platform shall be adopted as an open government transparency tool in direct support of the National Assembly's oversight function enabling citizens to track legislative proceedings, committee activities, and executive compliance with legislative directives in real time. The National Assembly commits to institutionalising NASS Eye as a core component of its oversight infrastructure.
11. A dedicated ICT-specific procurement framework, with a trained IT procurement cadre embedded in all MDAs and aggregated procurement coordination through the National Shared Services Centre, shall be developed and enforced. Technology procurement shall no longer be treated as equivalent to the procurement of physical goods.
12. A permanent Multi-Stakeholder Digital Governance Council (comprising the National Assembly, the Judiciary, the Office of the Head of the Civil Service of the Federation, the Office of the Secretary to the Government of the Federation, other key government agencies relevant to the digital governance agenda (NITDA, NDPC), key government owned entities such as Galaxy Backbone Ltd, NIBSS Plc, state government representatives, the private sector, OGP, and other civil society) shall be constituted to harmonise digital policies, eliminate investment duplication, and track implementation.
13. Progress on all commitments adopted in this Communiqué shall be reviewed at the National GovTech Policy Roundtable 2027. The standard of measurement shall not be the policies gazetted or the applications launched, but the experience of the Nigerian citizen; in whether government is responsive, accessible, trustworthy, and just.
14. The Communiqué was read and adopted as an aftermath of the inaugural edition of the NATIONAL GOVTECH POLICY ROUNDTABLE, held on the 30th Day of March, 2026 at the National Assembly Library and Resource Centre.



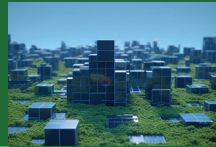
Signed

Fortune Toma
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